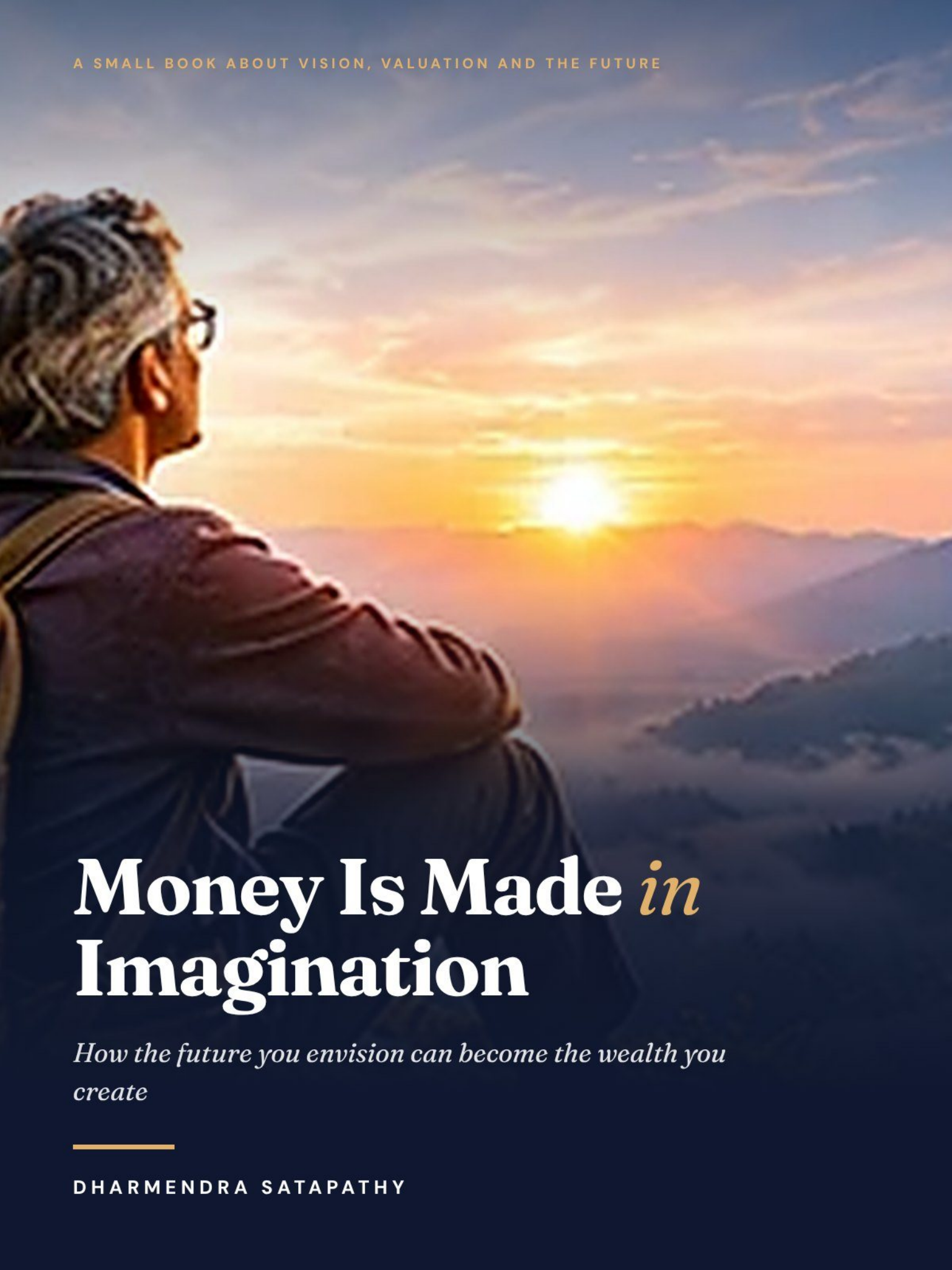
A SMALL BOOK ABOUT VISION, VALUATION AND THE FUTURE



Money Is Made *in* Imagination

How the future you envision can become the wealth you create

DHARMENDRA SATAPATHY



Can You Live Ten Times Your Life?

A human being has a limited lifetime.

Perhaps thirty productive years. Perhaps fifty.

But what if the economic value of what you create could extend far beyond those years?

What if you could build something that continues to grow, serve and prosper long after you are gone?

And what if the world could reward you today for a future you may never personally experience?

This is the extraordinary idea behind enterprise valuation.

We cannot extend our biological lives through business.

But we can imagine a future beyond our lifetime, build an institution capable of participating in that future, and receive economic recognition for its possibilities today.

> **Your life may be finite. The future you create need not be.**

And everything begins with imagination.



Every Business Is Born Twice

Every great enterprise is born twice.

First, in somebody's imagination.

Then, in the real world.

Before there was an airport, somebody imagined people flying between cities.

Before there was a smartphone, somebody imagined a world in which computing, communication and information could travel in a pocket.

Before a merchant could accept a digital payment through a simple code, somebody imagined making transactions dramatically easier.

Nothing existed physically when these possibilities were first imagined.

There were no revenues.

No customers.

No valuations.

Only an imagined future.

Yet that invisible beginning eventually became the foundation of enormous economic activity.

We often celebrate the finished enterprise and overlook the moment when somebody first saw a possibility that others could not.

> **The first asset of every entrepreneur is not money. It is the ability to imagine what does not yet exist.**



The Invisible Factory of Wealth

We associate wealth creation with factories, buildings, machines, technology and capital.

But many of the world's most valuable enterprises possess something that cannot be photographed.

An idea of how tomorrow could work differently.

A factory produces what it has been designed to manufacture.

Imagination designs the factory itself.

More importantly, imagination can redesign an entire industry.

It can see a different customer experience, a different distribution system or a different way for people to participate in economic activity.

That is why two entrepreneurs with similar resources may create vastly different enterprises.

One sees what already exists.

The other sees what could exist.

They may begin with the same capital, talent and market.

But they are building towards different futures.

> **Resources determine what you can do today. Imagination influences what you attempt to make possible tomorrow.**



Imagination Is Not Daydreaming

Not every imagination creates wealth.

An exciting idea is not necessarily a valuable idea.

People imagine extraordinary possibilities every day.

Most never become economically meaningful.

The difference lies in translating imagination into reality.

Can the idea solve a meaningful problem?

Can it be executed?

Will people adopt it?

Can its creator capture enough economic value to sustain it?

Imagination is the beginning, not the complete journey.

An entrepreneur must connect possibility with execution, usefulness and economic sustainability.

A useful way to think about it is through four bridges:

IMAGINATION → EXECUTION → ADOPTION → VALUE CAPTURE

An idea that never gets executed remains a thought.

An invention nobody adopts remains a possibility.

A widely used innovation without sustainable economics may create tremendous value for society but little wealth for its creator.

> **Imagination creates the opportunity. Execution and adoption make it real. Sound economics make it sustainable.**



The Difference Between Desire and Vision

Two people may build businesses for very different reasons.

The first asks:

How much money can I make?

The second asks:

What kind of future can I help create?

Both questions can inspire effort, ambition and achievement.

But they direct imagination differently.

Desire often begins with the individual.

Vision extends beyond the individual.

Desire imagines the rewards of success.

Vision imagines a future in which others can participate and benefit.

A desire may encourage someone to build a profitable business.

A vision may inspire customers, employees, partners and investors to collectively build something much larger.

Neither guarantees success.

But their horizons are different.

> **Desire imagines what you can gain. Vision imagines what you can make possible.**

Desire Makes You Profitable. Vision Makes You Valuable.

A successful professional may earn an excellent income for decades.

The income rewards personal skill, effort, expertise and judgement.

But what happens when the professional stops working?

If the entire business depends on that individual, much of its earning capacity may weaken.

Now consider someone who builds systems, develops people, creates a trusted brand and establishes enduring customer relationships.

The business begins acquiring capabilities independent of the person who created it.

It can continue serving customers.

It can expand under new leadership.

It can create value even when its founder is absent.

The distinction is not that profit is unimportant.

Profit is essential.

But profit and enterprise valuation answer different questions.

> **Profit asks what the business earns. Valuation asks what the business may be worth as a source of future economic benefits.**

And vision can help create that future.

Vision Is an Invitation

A personal ambition can be achieved alone.

A large vision usually cannot.

It needs the participation of other people.

Employees must believe their work matters.

Customers must see a better future for themselves.

Partners must find opportunities for mutual growth.

Leaders must have room to exercise their own judgement.

A powerful vision is therefore not simply a statement about what a founder wants to achieve.

It is an invitation for others to see themselves in a future worth creating.

This changes the nature of entrepreneurship.

The founder is no longer the only person imagining possibilities.

The enterprise attracts the imagination of others.

Ideas multiply.

Capabilities deepen.

The future becomes larger than the founder's original conception.

> **Imagination makes you see a future. Vision makes others see themselves in it.**

Happiness May Be Hiding in Usefulness

Why does creating something valuable for others feel so deeply satisfying?

The philosophy associated with Alfred Adler, explored in *The Courage to Be Disliked*, offers an interesting answer.

Happiness is closely connected with the feeling that we are contributing to others.

Think of an entrepreneur who builds an organisation that provides livelihoods, opportunities, reliable services and meaningful progress.

The founder may experience financial success.

But there may be another source of happiness.

The knowledge that other people's lives are better because the enterprise exists.

A business can provide personal rewards.

A vision can provide a reason to keep contributing even after personal financial needs have been satisfied.

This does not mean usefulness guarantees happiness.

But it offers a more enduring basis for fulfilment than applause or status alone.

> **Vision can make you happy before it makes you wealthy.**



The Difference Between Being Important and Being Useful

There are two ways to feel important.

One is to have people depend on you.

The other is to help people become capable without you.

The first places you at the centre.

The second places your contribution at the centre.

A leader who enjoys being indispensable may unconsciously create dependence.

Decisions accumulate on the leader's desk.

People hesitate to act independently.

The organisation appears successful, but its growth remains limited by one person's attention.

Another leader takes pride in developing capable people.

Delegation becomes a responsibility rather than a sacrifice.

Success is measured by what others can accomplish.

The irony is profound.

> **The more people you make dependent on yourself, the more important you may feel. The more people you make independent, the more enduring your contribution may become.**

The Trap of Vertical Relationships

Human relationships are often organised around comparisons.

Who is richer?

Who is more accomplished?

Who has greater authority?

Who deserves admiration?

This is the world of vertical relationships.

People begin to see themselves as above or below others.

In business, such thinking can become particularly seductive.

A founder may begin measuring personal worth through the dependence of employees, partners and customers.

The organisation becomes a stage on which the founder's importance is repeatedly demonstrated.

But this creates a hidden cost.

People may stop disagreeing.

New leaders may hesitate to emerge.

Independent initiative may be interpreted as a challenge to authority.

> **A hierarchy is necessary for decision-making. A hierarchy of human worth is not.**

An enterprise can have clear reporting relationships without turning every human interaction into a contest of superiority.



The Power of Horizontal Relationships

Horizontal relationships begin with a different belief.

People may have different responsibilities, capabilities, incomes and achievements.

But they need not have different human worth.

A senior leader can respect a junior employee as an equal human being.

An entrepreneur can appreciate a partner without needing to dominate the relationship.

An experienced professional can help a younger colleague grow without expecting lifelong dependence.

Horizontal relationships make contribution more important than comparison.

They encourage people to develop independent competence.

They create room for disagreement, experimentation and initiative.

And they allow the enterprise to benefit from perspectives beyond those of its founder.

This is not the abandonment of leadership.

It is leadership without the need for superiority.

> **A vertical mindset asks, "Where do I stand above others?"**
> **A horizontal mindset asks, "What can we make possible together?"**

From ME to WE

There comes a moment in the life of an entrepreneur when personal capability is no longer enough.

The business has grown.

Opportunities have multiplied.

Customers expect more.

The founder can no longer personally attend to everything.

At this point, the entrepreneur faces a choice.

Protect personal centrality.

Or build collective capability.

The first choice can preserve the founder's feeling of control.

The second can release the organisation's potential.

From this transition comes a different kind of enterprise.

People do not merely carry out instructions.

They bring their own ideas.

Leaders are developed rather than permanently overshadowed.

The organisation becomes stronger because its members grow stronger.

> **The journey from skill to scale is also a journey from ME to WE.**

It is not simply a change in management technique.

It is a change in the founder's relationship with success.

Who Does Your Brand Really Serve?

Why do we build brands?

Sometimes, the answer is uncomfortable.

To be recognised.

To be admired.

To become a familiar face.

To feel significant.

There is nothing inherently wrong with recognition.

But recognition becomes a limitation when it is the primary purpose of the brand.

A brand built around a single personality can become dependent on that personality's visibility, judgement and continued involvement.

Now imagine another kind of brand.

Customers trust it because of consistent experiences.

Employees value it because it creates opportunities.

Partners associate with it because collaboration is rewarding.

Future leaders can represent it without imitating its founder.

> **The brand no longer exists primarily to make one person important.**

It exists to create value for many stakeholders.

That is a very different ambition.



Build a Brand That Makes Others Important

A brand becomes more enduring when people beyond its founder have reasons to care about its success.

Customers must feel that it understands and serves them.

Employees must see meaningful futures within it.

Partners must discover commercial opportunities.

Future leaders must feel that their contributions matter.

A strong brand creates a shared promise.

Its value is not limited to the founder's personal reputation.

Consider an institution whose customers remain loyal when leadership changes.

Whose employees take pride in the organisation, not merely in proximity to the founder.

Whose partners continue collaborating because the relationship is economically and professionally meaningful.

Such a brand has begun to acquire an identity of its own.

> **Don't build a brand that proves your importance. Build a brand that makes others important.**

A brand is especially valuable when its promise survives the absence of the person who first made it.

The Many Stakeholders of an Enduring Enterprise

Imagine a circle with the founder at its centre.

Every relationship depends on reaching that centre.

Every important decision moves through it.

Every opportunity waits for its attention.

The circle may grow, but its centre becomes increasingly congested.

Now imagine a network.

Customers interact with capable teams.

Partners collaborate with one another.

Leaders create new opportunities.

Knowledge circulates through systems.

Value is exchanged across the organisation.

The founder remains important, but no longer needs to be involved in every interaction.

The enterprise becomes a place where many relationships can thrive.

This is the deeper purpose of building with stakeholders rather than building merely for self-importance.

> **A personality attracts attention. An institution organises contribution.**

And an ecosystem can take this principle even further.



Don’t Just Build an Aircraft

An aircraft can be an extraordinary machine.

It takes passengers from one destination to another.

Its commercial success depends on how well it operates, how often it flies and how efficiently it serves travellers.

Now think about an airport.

An airport enables thousands of aircraft movements.

It supports airlines, restaurants, hotels, logistics, maintenance services, retailers, transport operators and countless other businesses.

The aircraft performs an activity.

The airport creates the conditions for many activities.

Both can be valuable businesses.

But their economic architectures are different.

One earns from its own operations.

The other can participate in a much wider web of activity.

This distinction points towards a powerful entrepreneurial question.

> **Are you building something that performs?**
> **Or are you building something that enables thousands of others to perform?**

Sometimes the greatest opportunity is not to build another aircraft.

It is to build the runway.

The Long Runway Theory

A runway does not decide where every aircraft will fly.

It provides the infrastructure that makes many journeys possible.

The people who build it do not need to imagine every destination.

Others will do that.

The same principle applies to enterprises.

A powerful platform allows participants to develop products, services and business models that its creators may never have imagined.

The founder's imagination begins the journey.

The imagination of others expands it.

The runway becomes valuable because people find reasons to use it.

But simply constructing a runway is not enough.

It must attract sustained activity.

It must remain relevant.

And its economics must support maintenance, improvement and continued investment.

> **The longest runway is not necessarily the most valuable. The most valuable runway is one on which others repeatedly find compelling reasons to build and grow.**

The Mobile Phone: An Industry in Your Pocket

Consider the mobile phone.

It was once primarily a device for communication.

Today, the smartphone supports an astonishing variety of economic activity.

Developers create applications.

Teachers reach students.

Creators build audiences.

Merchants reach customers.

Drivers find passengers.

Banks deliver services.

Small entrepreneurs operate businesses from devices they can carry in their pockets.

No single manufacturer could have individually designed every application or business that would emerge from this ecosystem.

Much of the innovation came from other participants.

The technology created a foundation upon which the imagination of millions could operate.

This illustrates an important distinction.

> **A product can succeed because people use it.**
> **A platform can become consequential because people build upon it.**

That difference can dramatically expand the possibilities of economic value creation.



QR Codes and UPI: The Power of Enabling Others

Consider the simplicity of a QR code.

A small pattern can connect a physical object to digital information, services or transactions.

Now consider India's Unified Payments Interface, UPI.

Its infrastructure enables different banks, applications and payment participants to interact through a common framework.

Together with widespread smartphones and digital connectivity, such technologies have reduced friction in everyday commerce.

A street vendor can accept a digital payment.

A small business can serve customers without expensive payment infrastructure.

A software company can build services around digital transactions.

The remarkable lesson is not that every participant becomes wealthy.

Nor that the infrastructure itself captures all the economic value created.

The lesson is that **a relatively simple enabling mechanism can unlock possibilities for an enormous number of people.**

Sometimes the biggest innovation is not a new business.

It is making thousands of businesses possible.

When Other People's Imagination Joins Yours

An entrepreneur has limited time.

Limited attention.

Limited knowledge.

And even a limited imagination.

But what happens when an enterprise enables many other people to imagine and create?

Possibilities begin multiplying beyond the founder's personal capacity.

A developer discovers a new application.

A partner identifies a previously overlooked customer segment.

An employee improves a process.

A customer finds an unexpected use.

Each participant contributes something the original founder may not have anticipated.

The enterprise becomes more than the execution of one person's original plan.

It becomes a setting in which new possibilities continually emerge.

This is one of the most fascinating features of a successful ecosystem.

> **The founder does not need to imagine every future.**

The founder needs to build something that allows useful futures to be discovered by others.



Creating Value Is Not the Same as Capturing Value

There is an important economic distinction.

Enabling a great deal of value for society does not automatically produce an equally large valuation for the enabler.

Some innovations become public infrastructure.

Some benefit users primarily through lower costs.

Some create extraordinary opportunities for businesses built on top of them.

Their social impact can be enormous even when direct monetisation is limited.

Therefore, an entrepreneur building a runway must answer two questions.

> **First: How much value can this enable for others?**
> **Second: How can the enterprise sustainably participate in the value it enables?**

That participation might come through subscriptions, services, licensing, transactions or other legitimate economic arrangements.

The strongest systems often make the interests of the platform and its participants mutually reinforcing.

As participants prosper, the platform becomes more useful.

As the platform improves, participants discover more opportunities.

> **Great imagination creates possibilities. Great enterprise design makes those possibilities economically sustainable.**



Systems Allow Imagination to Survive

Imagination begins with people.

But its continued economic value often depends on systems.

Consider an entrepreneur who builds a successful business through personal relationships, instinct and relentless effort.

The business may earn substantial profits.

But much of its intelligence remains inside one person's mind.

Now imagine translating that intelligence into documented processes, trained teams, useful technology, institutional knowledge and reliable operating standards.

The enterprise begins developing a memory beyond its founder.

Customers receive consistent service.

Employees can make informed decisions.

New leaders can assume responsibility.

The business becomes less dependent on any one individual's presence.

This transformation is not merely operational.

It changes the duration and predictability of the enterprise's future earning capacity.

> **Skill creates today's performance. Systems give tomorrow a better chance of repeating it.**

The Future Pays Today

Here lies one of the most extraordinary features of valuation.

A buyer does not pay for an enterprise merely because it has performed well in the past.

The buyer primarily cares about the economic benefits that ownership may produce in the future.

How large might those benefits become?

How long might they last?

How dependable are they?

What risks could prevent them from materialising?

The market attempts to translate these uncertain future possibilities into a present value.

Future cash flows are discounted because money received later is not equivalent to money received today, and because the future is uncertain.

The entrepreneur may therefore receive economic recognition today for years of future activity.

But valuation is not automatically cash in the founder's pocket.

That requires a transaction or another way of monetising ownership.

> **Valuation is the present economic expression of a future that others believe may be worth owning.**



Can Valuation Make You Live Ten Times Your Life?

Return to our original question.

Can valuation make a person live ten times their lifetime?

Not biologically.

Not literally.

But economically, something fascinating is possible.

A founder may have only twenty years of active working life remaining.

Yet the enterprise being built could remain relevant for fifty, seventy-five or even a hundred years.

Its systems may continue operating.

Its brand may continue attracting customers.

Its people may continue creating new opportunities.

And investors may recognise some of that long-term potential in the enterprise's value today.

The founder need not personally experience every future year.

The institution can carry the economic activity forward.

And ownership can provide a claim on some of that anticipated future.

> **Imagination allows you to reach beyond your lifetime.**
> **Valuation can reward you today for a portion of the future you have made credible.**

That is the remarkable connection between time, imagination and wealth.

The Price of Believing in Tomorrow

There is a difference between an imagined future and a credible future.

Two entrepreneurs may describe equally ambitious visions.

One possesses a charismatic presentation.

The other has customers, recurring revenues, capable leadership, reliable systems, evidence of demand and a realistic path to growth.

The second entrepreneur offers more than an attractive possibility.

There is evidence that the enterprise may deliver.

This is why institutional capabilities matter so much to valuation.

Growth potential influences the magnitude of future earnings.

Recurring relationships influence predictability.

Leadership and systems influence continuity.

Customer concentration, competition and founder dependence influence risk.

Valuation is therefore not simply a reward for dreaming further into the future.

It is a judgement about whether the future can plausibly be delivered.

> **Imagination creates the horizon. Credibility creates confidence in reaching it.**

The ₹150 Crore Paradox

Imagine two mutual fund distribution businesses.

The first manages ₹500 crore of client assets.

The founder personally handles major relationships, decisions and business development.

The second manages ₹150 crore.

But it has built a trained team, institutional relationships, dependable systems, recurring processes and a brand capable of serving clients without constant founder involvement.

The larger practice may generate considerably more current income.

Yet the smaller enterprise may possess stronger institutional foundations.

There is also a fundamental distinction between managing client assets and owning a business asset.

The ₹500 crore under management does not belong to the distributor.

What the distributor owns is the business: its economic rights, earnings, client relationships, systems, brand and operating capabilities.

Actual valuations would still depend on revenues, margins, retention and risk.

But the paradox remains.

> **The scale of what you manage is not necessarily the measure of what you have built.**

The Founder Who Became Unnecessary

Most founders begin by being indispensable.

They make the decisions.

They win the customers.

They solve the problems.

They provide the energy that keeps everything moving.

Initially, this is often a strength.

Eventually, it can become a constraint.

The founder's attention has limits.

An institution capable of growing beyond those limits must develop independent competence.

A capable leadership team.

Shared knowledge.

Clear decision rights.

Trustworthy systems.

Relationships that belong to the enterprise rather than exclusively to the individual.

This requires a peculiar kind of courage.

The courage to become less central to the very enterprise you created.

But becoming less necessary to daily operations does not mean becoming less valuable as a founder.

It may mean the opposite.

> **Your greatest achievement may be creating something that no longer requires your constant presence to succeed.**

What Should Your Imagination Leave Behind?

At some point, every entrepreneur must confront the limits of personal achievement.

How much money is enough?

How much recognition is enough?

How much personal importance is enough?

These questions cannot be answered through valuation alone.

Perhaps a more meaningful question is:

What will remain useful because I was here?

A trusted institution.

An opportunity for someone else.

A livelihood.

A system that makes people's lives easier.

A brand that future generations can develop.

A platform upon which people build things we cannot yet imagine.

These possibilities give imagination a purpose beyond accumulation.

They also help explain why contribution can be a source of lasting happiness.

Wealth can reward the creator.

But usefulness allows the creation to continue mattering to others.

> **The deepest legacy may not be what you leave to people, but what you make possible for them.**



The Longest Runway

Imagine an entrepreneur standing beside an empty runway.

There are no aircraft.

No passengers.

No businesses around it.

Only a belief that something extraordinary could happen here.

Years pass.

The runway becomes an airport.

People travel.

Businesses flourish.

New opportunities emerge.

Many were never imagined by the person who first envisioned the runway.

Eventually, the founder is no longer there.

But the aircraft continue taking off.

The runway continues serving.

The future continues unfolding.

And somewhere along that journey, the world may have rewarded the founder for the economic possibilities created.

That is the wonder of imagination.

It begins in one human mind.

It can become useful to millions.

And it can continue creating value beyond the lifetime of its creator.

> **Money is made in imagination.**
> **But the greatest imagination is not merely the one that makes you wealthy.**
> **It is the one that makes you useful to a future larger than yourself.**

— Dharmendra Satapathy